

3, The Unfavorable Factors Impeding Feudalization in the Islamic World

Under the shockwaves of the Great Turkic Migrations, Islamic society ultimately and inevitably marched toward **feudalization**. However, one can clearly observe that the Middle Ages of the Islamic world ultimately failed to evolve like the Middle Ages of Europe. **Early modern society** never crystallized within Islamic states; the people never reclaimed rationalism or humanism, but rather, fundamentalism intensified with terrifying ferocity.

Why did this happen?

I believe the present-day Islamic Republic of Iran serves as an excellent observation subject. If we trace history from the aftermath of the Mongol devastation of the Middle East, it is easy to realize that the power of the "Twelvers" (十二伊玛目派 / *Twelver Shi'ism*) in the Iranian region steadily ballooned over time. They gradually hijacked the grassroots social organizations, ultimately steering Iran into a theocratic, church-state-integrated (政教合一) nation in the latter half of the last century.

The transformations experienced by Iran bear universal significance across the Islamic world.

Unlike China, shielded behind a massive plateau, or Europe, which itself is a colossal extended peninsula, the Islamic world—stretching from the Atlantic Ocean to the Roof of the World—is situated in an excessively "open" geographic position. The plains, river valleys, and intermontane basins suitable for serving as the foundational heartlands of mighty states are relentlessly severed by rolling mountain ranges and vast deserts. Furthermore, their individual scale is never large enough, and there simply does not exist a single geographic unit that possesses an overwhelming superiority in both economy and manpower.

For the **feudal** Islamic regimes of the Middle Ages, dangerous barbarians were constantly marauding along their peripheries, yet the strength required to repel these incursions was perpetually too feeble. Within a vast expanse stretching tens of thousands of miles, teeming with countless nomadic tribes, the emergence of a few leaders possessing **Charismatic authority** (卡里斯玛式领袖) was by no means a low-probability event.

Furthermore, in the direction where the Islamic world faced the devastating incursions of formidable nomadic peoples from the Eurasian Steppe—namely, Central Asia—the actual geopolitical landscape was even more detrimental.

Unlike the northern plains of China or the plains of France and Hungary in Europe, Central Asia completely lacked contiguous, densely populated agricultural settlement zones (面状的定居区). Instead, its towns formed a **pointillist structure** (点状结构) with commercial cities functioning as the core nodes.

This grim physical reality inflicted three fatal difficulties upon the feudal Muslim regimes:

First, the distances between major settlements were exceedingly vast, and regional population density was low. This obviously maximized the mobility advantage of nomadic peoples whose military backbone consisted entirely of cavalry.

Second, although prior to the Industrial Revolution, the core economy of any region that had undergone the agricultural revolution was inevitably agriculture, in Central Asia, trade networks were equally vital to local regimes. Therefore, a nomadic army did not even need to besiege a city to bring its enemies to their knees! It simply needed to launch relentless raids, driving trade costs so

astronomically high that commercial routes were severed. The defending enemy would instantly find themselves in an utterly unsustainable predicament.

Finally, the agricultural situation of the entire region relied extremely heavily on highly complex **irrigation systems**. This sharply contrasts with regions enjoying relatively abundant precipitation, such as Europe and China.

If we observe the siege warfare during Japan's Sengoku period (战国时期), this point is effortlessly apparent. Under Japan's subtropical monsoon climate, the cost of rebuilding simple irrigation systems was incredibly low. Therefore, once a feudal lord was attacked by an enemy, he could always consider resorting to *Rōjō* (笼城战 / retreating into the castle and enduring a siege). The attacking force could indeed ravage the agricultural properties and infrastructure within the defender's territory. But the moment the attackers were forced to retreat due to logistical and economic constraints (*e.g., their own territories also required cultivation*), it was not difficult for the defender to restore agricultural production within their domain.

This is exactly why fortresses like Odawara Castle (小田原城) earned the prestigious reputation of being "impregnable" (难攻不落). Only a regime like Toyotomi Hideyoshi's, which had essentially unified Japan, possessed the capacity to utterly crush the opponent in a war of attrition!

But the situation in Central Asia is drastically different. When defenders are forced to retreat into their fortresses for defense, the attackers have absolute freedom to destroy the above-ground or underground irrigation canals in the surrounding countryside. Constructing them is arduous, but destroying them is terrifyingly easy!

Even if the attackers lift the siege and withdraw that year, it is impossible for the defenders to recover their strength in the short term. Therefore, when the attack comes again the following year, the defenders have already been fatally weakened. Furthermore, one could easily enumerate other factors detrimental to the defenders—for instance, the sheer lack of water constitutes a colossal threat to holding a city.

In conclusion, the physical realities of the Central Asian region made it exceedingly difficult for feudal lords to leverage the most prominent military advantage of a **feudal system**—namely, fighting a war of attrition through *Rōjō* (笼城作战 / enduring a siege).

Taking the Guanzhong region (关中地区) where I currently reside as a contrast makes this easy to understand. The Guanzhong region is densely populated, receives 600 millimeters of annual precipitation, and enjoys concurrent rain and heat (雨热同期). The commodity economy and wage labor relations of the entire region (in ancient times) were not developed in the slightest, not to mention how utterly negligible long-distance trade was as a proportion of the local economy.

Once a region like this undergoes **feudalization**, it inevitably presents a landscape bristling with fortresses. For barbarian conquerors, this is an absolute nightmare! Because for them, manpower is excruciatingly precious; even if they managed to gnaw such fortresses down by brute force, all their teeth would be shattered in the process.

The Islamic world not only had to face the massive, perilous frontier of Central Asia, but it never knew from which nearby mountain range (*e.g., Azerbaijan*) a few "tribal assassins" might suddenly emerge, sweeping across neighboring territories with overwhelming martial force.

Along the peripheries of already partially **feudalized** regions, there still existed vast numbers of un-feudalized tribes. Once these backward peoples also developed the intrinsic need for **feudalization** and gained the upper hand in military force, they were bound to seize the land into their own hands to execute a **feudalization** dominated by their own tribe!

Therefore, to borrow a trendy term, **the Islamic society of the Middle Ages was exactly like the "Chaotic Era" (乱纪元) in the novel *The Three-Body Problem* (《三体》)**. Just as the **feudalization** of a region reached a certain level of development, it was highly probable that conquerors emerging from nowhere would flip the board and force the entire process to start all over again!

The absolute greatest geopolitical advantage Europe possessed was its immunity to this stagnation. Because **all the devastating blows from the outer peripheries were absorbed by the Muslims!** The European heartland was rarely threatened by newly emerging **feudalized barbarians**.

Throughout the entire Middle Ages, the only barbarians worth mentioning in Europe were the Vikings from Scandinavia, but their threat was not even remotely comparable to the nomadic peoples of the Asian hinterland. When the Vikings launched a plundering raid, the absolute maximum was perhaps a little over a thousand men. Yet when nomadic tribes from the East closed in on the Middle East, mobilizing an army of tens of thousands was perfectly normal—and they were cavalry, a significant portion of whom were highly trained and even clad in heavy armor!

When the Vikings began expanding southward, though they initially caused considerable turmoil, they could only settle in frontier regions like Sicily or Normandy, and they underwent **feudalization** in exceptionally short order.

Iran is the most prominent victim of this **"Chaotic Era."**

The local political organizations of the state were progressively hollowed out amidst perennial turmoil. During nearly a century of internal and external wars following the disintegration of the Safavid Empire (萨菲王朝), they almost completely collapsed.

By the time of the Qajar Dynasty (恺加王朝), the religious power of the **"Twelvers"** had surged drastically relative to the monarch's power, securing a significant degree of independence from the secular dynasty. For example, in the judicial realm, the wealth—especially the landed estates—owned by the clerical stratum expanded massively.

During this period, the hierarchical institutionalization of the Iranian Shiite clergy (什叶派教阶制度) grew increasingly perfected. The development of this religious apparatus—which closely resembled a bureaucratic hierarchy—in the 19th century fully proves, from the flip side, that **the grassroots governance of the Iranian state had completely failed, and religious power had simply stepped in to fill the vacuum!**

Under this trajectory of development, the Iranian Islamic Revolution of 1979 does not seem surprising in the slightest.

Back then, Islamic society was dragged into the **feudal period**, dragging its feet and wholly reluctant, by the galloping nomads. Yet, it was subsequently trapped in prolonged stagnation by the endless waves of newly rising **feudalized** conquerors. One cannot help but call this an absolute social tragedy.

3, 伊斯兰世界面对的不利于封建化的因素

在突厥人大迁徙的冲击下, 伊斯兰社会总归是不可避免地走向了封建化, 然而人们显然可以注意到伊斯兰世界的中世纪最终没有像欧洲的中世纪一样演化, 近世社会并没有在伊斯兰国家形成, 人们没有找到理性和人文主义, 反倒是原教旨主义愈演愈烈。为什么会这样呢? 我认为现在的伊朗伊斯兰共和国是一个非常好的观察对象, 如果我们从蒙古扫荡中东之后看起, 就很容易意识到在伊朗地区的十二伊玛目派(Twelve Imams)的势力随着时间推移变得越来越大, 他们渐渐接管了社会基层组织, 并且在上个世纪后半叶使伊朗演化成为一个政教合一的神权国家。伊朗所经历的变化在伊斯兰世界具有普遍意义, 不同于庞大高原背后的中国以及欧洲这个延伸出来的巨大半岛, 从大西洋延伸到世界屋脊的伊斯兰世界处在一个过于“开放”的位置上, 适合作为强大国家基业的平原, 河谷以及山间盆地被连绵的山脉和沙漠隔开, 其规模又不够大, 更不存在某一个在经济和人力上占有显著优势的地理单元。对于中世纪的伊斯兰封建政权来说, 危险的蛮族总是在自己周边活动, 而抵御其侵袭的力量又太过弱小。在幅员万里内如此之多的游牧部落, 产生个别卡里斯玛式(Charismatic authority)的领袖并非小概率事件。

而在伊斯兰世界面对欧亚大草原强大游牧民族侵袭的方向, 也就是中亚地区, 实际的地缘形势更加不利。中亚不同于中国北方平原或者欧洲法国和匈牙利的平原, 这里不存在面状的, 人口密集的定居区, 其城镇形成了以商业城市为核心的点状结构。这种现实问题给封建的穆斯林政权带来了三个致命的困难, 首先大型定居点之间的间距十分可观, 区域人口密度不大, 对于以骑兵作为军事力量主干的游牧民族来说显然有利于发挥其机动性。其次虽然在工业革命之前全世界任何一个经历了农业革命的地区总归是以农业经济为主体, 但是在中亚这个地方, 贸易网络对于当地政权而言非常重要。因此游牧民族并不是非得要进行攻城才能使敌人屈服, 它只要通过不断袭击使得贸易成本变得过高以至于商路断绝, 防守的敌人就会立刻处于难以为继的地位。

最后整个地区的农业情况非常依赖于灌溉系统, 这与欧洲和中国降水量相对充足的地区差别很大。如果我们观察日本战国时期的围城战争就很容易注意到这一点, 在日本这样的亚热带季风气候下, 重建简单的灌溉系统的成本并不高。因此一旦领主遭到敌军攻击, 他总是可以考虑进行笼城战, 进攻方的确可以考虑去破坏防守方统治区的农业财产和设施, 但是进攻方一旦因为补给和经济问题(例如自己的领土也需要耕种)不得不撤军, 防守方想要恢复自己领内的农业生产并不困难。所以像小田原城这样的堡垒才有“难攻不落”的美誉, 只有已经基本统一日本的丰臣政权才有可能在消耗战中彻底击溃对方。

而中亚的情况大为不同, 当防守方被迫退入城中防御, 进攻方完全有机会破坏城市周围农村的地上或者地下的灌溉渠, 修建他们比较困难, 毁掉却容易得多。即使进攻方在当年的围困撤去, 防守方也不可能在短期内恢复实力, 因此第二年攻击再次到来的时候, 它就已经被大大削弱了。另外人们还可以轻而易举地列举出另一些对防御方不利的因素, 例如缺水本身对于守城就是巨大的威胁。总而言之, 中亚地区的现实情况使得封建领主难以发挥封建体制最为显著的军事优势, 那就是进行笼城作战。拿我现在所居住的关中地区作为对比就不难理解, 关中地区人口密集, 年均降水量 600 毫米, 雨热同期, 整个地区的商品经济和雇佣关系(在古代)一点都不发达, 更不要说长途贸易能够在当地经济中占什么比重了。像这种地区一旦封建化就必然呈现出堡垒林立的局面, 这对于蛮族征服者而言是极为恐怖的事情, 因为他们来说人力是极其宝贵的, 就算能够硬啃下来牙也都崩没了。

伊斯兰世界不但要面临中亚这一片庞大的危险边疆, 而且还不知道在附近的哪个山区(例如阿塞拜疆)里就突然冒出几个“部落刺客”以强大的武力横扫临近的地域。在已经部分封建化的地区边缘仍然存在大量没有封建化的部落, 一旦这些落后民族也具备了封建化的需求并且在武力上占据优势, 那么他们势必要将土地控制在自己手里进行本族主导的封建化。因此用一个时髦的话来说, 中世纪的伊斯兰社会就是小说《三体》中的乱纪元, 当一个地区的封建化达到一定程度之后, 很有可能不知何处而来的征服者就要再推倒重来一次。欧洲在地缘上最大的优势就在于它能够免于这种停滞, 因为所有外围的伤害都被穆斯林承受了, 欧洲腹地很难受到新兴封建化蛮族的威胁。在整个中世纪, 能值得一提的蛮族只有斯堪的纳维亚的维京人, 但是其威胁跟亚洲腹地的游牧民族根本没办法比。维京人一次劫掠进攻多者不过千余人, 来自东方的游牧部落逼近中东的时候集结几万军队是再正常不过了, 甚至还是骑兵, 其中相当部分训练有素甚至身披重甲。当维京人开始南下的时候, 他们最初虽然造成了不小的骚动, 但是也只能定居在西西里或者诺曼底这样的边疆地区, 并且在很快的时间内就封建化了。伊朗是这种“乱纪元”最为突出的受害者, 该国地方的政治组织在常年动乱中被愈发削弱, 在萨菲王朝解体后的近一个世纪的内外战争中几乎完全崩溃, 等到恺加王朝统治时, 十二伊玛目派的宗教权力相对于君主的权力就已经急

剧上升，取得了一定不依赖于世俗王朝的独立地位，例如在司法领域，教士阶层拥有的财富特别是土地也大为扩张。在这一时期，伊朗什叶派教阶制度日渐完善，这种接近于官僚等级制度的宗教体制在 19 世纪取得发展，从另一面充分证明了伊朗国家基层统治的彻底失效，宗教权力已经填补了这种空缺。在这种发展的形势下，1979 年的伊朗伊斯兰革命也就不显得奇怪了。当年伊斯兰社会拖拖拉拉不情不愿地被疾驰而来的游牧民卷入了封建时代，但是同样因为接踵而起的新晋封建化的征服者们而长期停滞于此，这不能不说是一种社会悲剧。